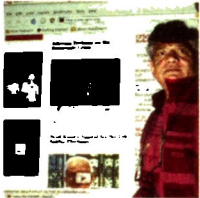


Nation **POLL DIARY**

The Usual SUSPECTS



The party that once opposed computerisation on grounds that it would deprive many of their jobs is on the defensive these days.

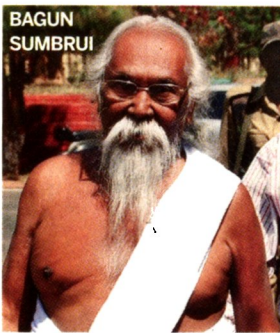
The CPI(M) is busy defending its website from cyber attacks from "class enemies". Its poll website, vote.cpim.org, was hacked as soon as it was launched. Attempts are on to trace the arsonists, but the CPI(M) suspects it is the 'Zionists and Imperialists' who had earlier hacked the party's website. *by Shafi Rahman*

BROTHER OUTLAWED

Lalu Prasad's carefully laid plans to run the country one day may come under threat from within. The railway minister's brother-in-law, Sadhu Yadav revolted after *jijaji* denied him a party ticket despite being a sitting MP. "Nobody can stop me from contesting elections," he said. The enemy within.

UN WELCOME

Keralites are known to be a hospitable lot who warmly welcome outsiders. But this is one native who is getting the cold-shoulder from his own people. When Shashi Tharoor, former UN under-secretary general, decided to contest the coming Lok Sabha elections on a Congress ticket, it was believed that the state would welcome this famous son of Kerala



BAGUN SUMBRUI

The Old War Horse

Bagun Sumbrui was 28 when the first Lok Sabha was elected in 1952. Last month, he celebrated his 85th birthday, but that wasn't the only reason he had to party. He was among the first Congress candidates cleared by the high command. Having never lost an election, no one doubts he will be back for a sixth term from Singhbhum.

MAHADEO SEN

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constituencies of the 543 going to the polls this time have been affected by the last round of delimitation.

Slumdog Prime Minister

If elections are here, can Jaspal Bhatti be far behind? In keeping with the times, the poker-faced satirist has named his outfit the "Recession Party". If elected, he will create more slums around Chandigarh, as he says, "every one has a chance at the Oscars".



NEHA NATH

Family PLOT

Trust Mamata Banerjee to do the unusual. Her party has nominated Shishir Adhikari and his son Subhendu as candidates for East Midnapore in West Bengal.



N. MADHAVAN

with open arms. But despite the backing of 10 Janpath, Tharoor faces stiff opposition from within the party. Some Congress MLAs and a former MP have asked the state party unit not to give ticket to "outsiders" and "parajumpers". A section of the Congress workers even took out a protest march and burnt his effigies. In anticipation of his candidature, the New York-based Tharoor had moved to Thiruvananthapuram three months ago. The writer-turned-dipomat-turned-wannabe politician is feeling the tropical heat in more ways than one.

by M.G. Radhakrishnan